

California woman’s dog voted twice

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(by Clara Harter, Los Angeles Times) – An Orange County woman faces five felony charges after she was accused of...fraud by registering her dog to vote and illegally casting ballots for the pooch in two elections, authorities said.

Laura Lee Yourex, 62, of Costa Mesa, allegedly mailed in ballots registered under her dog’s name, **Maya Jean Yourex**, in the 2021 gubernatorial recall election and the 2022 primary election, according to the Orange County district attorney’s office. The 2021 ballot was accepted, while the 2022 ballot was rejected, prosecutors said.

Yourex allegedly bragged about the feat on social media, sharing a picture of Maya toting an “I Voted” sticker and posing with the illegal ballot in January 2022, prosecutors said. In October, Yourex posted a photo of Maya’s dog tag and a vote-by-mail ballot with the caption, “Maya is still getting her ballot,” even though the dog had passed away.

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Yourex has been charged with one count of registering a nonexistent person to vote, one count of perjury, one count of procuring a false or forged document to be filed and two counts of casting a ballot when not entitled to vote, prosecutors said. Yourex is scheduled to be arraigned Tuesday.

If convicted as charged, Yourex faces up to six years in state prison.

The **Orange County Registrar of Voters [Bob Page]** contacted the district attorney's office on Oct. 28, 2024 after [Yourex] self-reported that she had registered her dog to vote and cast two ballots in her dog's name, authorities said.



A view of an official Orange County Registrar of Voters ballot drop box at Carl Thornton Park in Santa Ana on Oct. 13, 2020. (Allen J. Schaben / Los Angeles Times)

California residents must sign an affidavit under penalty of perjury to register to vote. While proof of residence is required for first-time voters to cast a ballot in a **federal** election, it is not required to cast a ballot in a **state** election. [California voter registration for state elections does not require proof of residence or identification, which made it possible for a ballot to be issued under the dog's name. The fraudulent registration went undetected due to limited safeguards for state election registration].

This is why the dog's ballot for the 2021 **state** election to recall Gov. Gavin Newsom was accepted, while the 2022 midterm elections ballot [a **federal** election] was rejected, prosecutors said.

The recall attempt was ultimately voted down by 61.9% of voters. It's not clear how "Maya" voted.

In June, the Trump administration filed a lawsuit against **Orange County Registrar of Voters Bob Page** for allegedly refusing to provide the Justice Department with records pertaining to the removal of people lacking documentation from its voter registration list. The Justice Department has sent letters to at least 26 states requesting details about voters, election processes and election officials.

In August, the Orange County Board of Supervisors voted to refuse to comply with the DOJ's demands to turn over the voter registration records of 17 individuals who were ineligible to cast a ballot but had appeared on the county's voter registration rolls.

The O.C. Registrar of Voters faced [criticism] over the integrity of the 2024 election after...allegations of forged signatures, non-U.S. citizens voting and duplicated ballots circulated on social media.

In January, the **Orange County Grand Jury** published a report concluding that **the Registrar exhibited the "highest level of integrity" in the 2024 election** and that there was no evidence of voter fraud.

[Yourex is scheduled to be arraigned at the Stephen K. Tamura West Justice Center in Westminster, California, on Sept. 9, 2025, according to the DA's office. She faces a maximum sentence of six years in state prison if convicted on all counts, prosecutors said.]

Times staff writers Hannah Fry and Gabriel San Román contributed to this report.

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Questions

1. The first paragraph of a news article should answer the questions who, what, where and when. (In this article, 1st and 2nd paragraphs). List the who, what, where and when of this news item. (NOTE: The remainder of a news article provides details on the why and/or how.)
2. How/when did the Orange County Registrar of Voters Bob Page discover Yourex's voter fraud?
3. What evidence was there to back up Yourex's claim that her dog Maya voted?
4. a) What charges have been brought against Ms. Yourex?
b) What sentence does she face if convicted?
5. Why was Yourex able to register her dog to vote?
6. In a Newsweek report on the same story, the reporter writes:
"President Donald Trump has repeatedly claimed, without evidence, that widespread voter fraud occurs through mail voting and has vowed to eliminate the practice."
And also from the same Newsweek article:
"California election officials, however, maintain that cases of voter fraud are extremely rare in the state, with safeguards in place to detect and reject invalid ballots. In August, Trump vowed to sign an executive order to end the use of mail-in ballots and voting machines ahead of the 2026 midterm elections."
a) Why do you think the "safeguards in place to detect and reject invalid ballots" did not prevent Yourex's dog from voting?
b) How to register to vote in California:
-California does not require an ID to register to vote
-When you register online or on a paper form, you are asked to provide your California driver's license or ID card number, or the last four digits of your Social Security number. If you do not have a driver's license, state ID, or Social Security number, you can still complete your registration by leaving those fields blank.